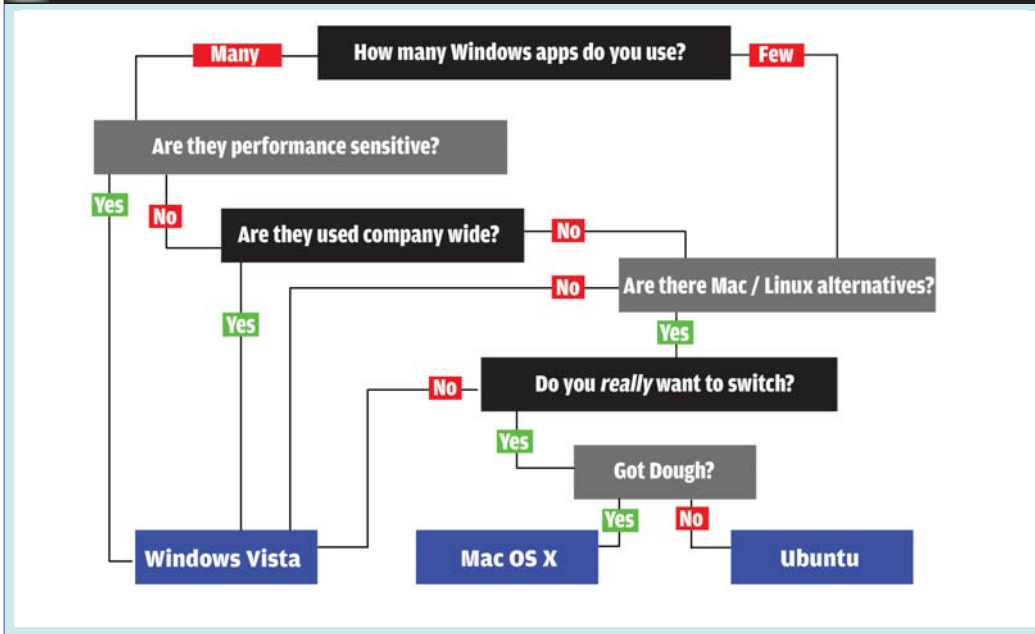




Decision Maker



istrator on the first run, and User Account Control (UAC) ensures that every application making changes to the system is authorised to do so. UAC can be a bit of an annoyance sometimes, and the fact that there's an option to turn it off is its first flaw. In Linux and OS X, any application that's making modifications to the system needs you to enter the root password, so even if malicious code does enter your machine, it can't do anything without root access.

The *nix architecture—on which both OS X and Linux are based—is inherently more secure. Nobody can argue with that. If you're going the Vista way, don't forsake your anti-virus and anti-spyware tools anytime soon.

The Laptop Experience

Most of what we've talked about thus far applies both for laptops and Desktops, but there are a few things exclusive to laptops. If you own, or plan to buy, a tablet PC with Vista, you're in for a treat. Tablet support has been built into Vista from scratch, so it doesn't feel like the hack that Windows XP Tablet PC Edition felt like. You can use your handwriting to enter text in any field that accepts it—the handwriting dialog is always waiting in a corner of the screen. Handwriting recognition is impressive to start with, and gets better as it learns your nuances. You can also assign "Pen Flicks" for common tasks like copying text or executing a keyboard shortcut.

When you go the Mac way, you get to enjoy the great touchpad features. The touchpad driver responds to touches from two fingers as well, so while you can use a single finger to move the mouse cursor and tap to click, using two fingers lets you scroll and tapping with two fingers becomes a right-click. As you start getting used to this, the single click button at the bottom of the touchpad starts to seem redundant.

Linux users have some respite, though—there is a Linux driver written for Synaptics touchpads (nearly all laptops use them) that lets you use multiple fingers—find it at http://tuxmobil.org/touchpad_driver.html—assuming your hardware supports it.

The Bottom Line

Just like on Desktops, Vista is the safe choice. It's Windows, so it's familiar territory, applications are in abundance, you'll get it pre-installed on a nice, reasonably-priced laptop today, and the tablet PC experience is another feather in its cap.

Between the two Linux distributions, we recommend Ubuntu, with paid support to help you through your growing pains (find the Indian support firms at <http://www.ubuntu.com/support/commercial/marketplace/asia>). It's quite gentle on the first-time user, but you need to tweak a lot of options to make it suit your needs—too many—and sometimes even simple things like installing PostScript fonts to work with a Windows application under Wine can turn out to be mammoth tasks. When things go wrong with Linux, they usually go horribly wrong.

In terms of the overall experience, OS X on a MacBook or MacBook Pro comes up tops. You don't have to worry yourself about the latest viruses (unless there's a new Mac virus), you don't have to "spring clean" if it starts to get sluggish—which it doesn't, regular format-reinstalls will be a thing of the past, and the touchpad experience sets it apart from the competition. It's quite the idiot-proof OS as well—and it still stands strong. The only trouble is the price—an entry-level MacBook costs Rs 67,000, and the MacBook Pro starts at Rs 1,15,800. If you've got the money and have no Windows-only applications tying you down, head to the nearest Apple retailer. ☒

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com